
New Guinea Pig Guide



Everything you need for a happy, confident
start together — from shopping lists to
first-week wisdom, the Cleo way.

Before Cleo Arrives

The welcome-home shopping list



The essentials

- ☐ Cage — at least 7.5 sq ft for one guinea pig, or 10.5+ sq ft for a bonded pair
- ☐ Water bottle or heavy bowl
- ☐ Hay rack + unlimited Timothy hay
- ☐ At least 2 hideouts per guinea pig
- ☐ Fleece or paper-based bedding (not cedar/pine shavings)
- ☐ Guinea-pig-specific pellets
- ☐ A daily vitamin C source

The happy extras

- ☐ Tunnels & chew toys
- ☐ Lap pad for handling time
- ☐ Soft grooming brush
- ☐ Small-animal nail clippers
- ☐ A bonded cage mate — they're a highly social species
- ☐ Exercise pen for floor time

Cleo's tip

Guinea pigs do best with at least one companion of their own kind. If yours is alone, consider a proper bonded introduction with a vet's guidance.



The First Week



Slow and gentle wins every heart

DAYS
1-2

Quiet settling

Have hay and water ready immediately. Keep the first days quiet — loud noises and heavy handling can be overwhelming. A cardboard box with two entrances makes a great cheap hideout — guinea pigs like an escape route, not a dead end.

DAYS
3-4

Soft hellos

Sit near the cage and talk softly. Offer a small piece of vegetable by hand, but let them approach at their own pace. A little popcorning (a happy hop) is a great sign — it means they're starting to feel safe enough to be playful.

DAYS
5-7

Gentle handling

Begin brief, supported handling sessions. Watch for wheeking (excitement) and popcorning (joy) as trust builds. Many guinea pigs learn to wheel with excitement the moment they hear your footsteps — a lovely sign of a growing bond.

WEEK
2+

Settling into routine

Establish a daily hay/veggie/floor-time rhythm and book a first check-up with an exotics-experienced vet. If you don't already have a second guinea pig, ask your vet or a rescue about bonding — they're a highly social species.



Feeding Basics

Happy tummies, healthy bodies



How much & how often

- 🐾 Hay available 24/7 — it should be about 80% of their diet
- 🐾 Best daily veggie: red bell pepper — it's the best source of vitamin C, which guinea pigs can't make on their own
- 🐾 Daily greens: romaine or leaf lettuce, plus herbs like cilantro, basil, dill, and thyme (go lighter on parsley and mint, which are higher in calcium) — skip iceberg lettuce, which has little nutrition
- 🐾 Pellets measured, not free-fed (roughly 1/8 cup per guinea pig per day)
- 🐾 Fresh water always available
- 🐾 Introduce any new food gradually to avoid digestive upset

Treats (a few times a week, not daily)

- 🐾 Carrots — 1-2 thin slices, just 1-2 times a week (higher in sugar than leafy greens)
- 🐾 Blueberries — a few at a time, a couple times a week
- 🐾 Apple — a small wedge, seeds removed, only occasionally

Never feed your guinea pig

- 🐾 Onions, garlic & the allium family
- 🐾 Avocado, chocolate & anything sugary
- 🐾 Dairy or meat of any kind — strict herbivores
- 🐾 Iceberg lettuce (empty calories, diarrhea risk)
- 🐾 Rhubarb & raw beans
- 🐾 Cedar or pine shavings as bedding (respiratory irritant)

If something risky gets eaten

Call your vet or the ASPCA Animal Poison Control Center right away:

(888) 426-4435 — available 24/7



A Guinea Pig-Safe Home

Curiosity-proofing 101



Plants to keep far away

- 🐾 Lilies, tulips, daffodils & other bulb flowers
- 🐾 Azalea, oleander & foxglove
- 🐾 Any unwashed, unidentified, or pesticide-treated greenery

Safe greenery instead

- 🐾 Basil
- 🐾 Cilantro
- 🐾 Parsley (in moderation)
- 🐾 Mint
- 🐾 Dill
- 🐾 Spider plant (safe ornamental option)

Around the house

- 🐾 Cage away from direct sun, drafts, and loud household noise
- 🐾 Keep floor-time areas free of cords and small chewable objects
- 🐾 A quiet exotics vet visit early on catches problems before they grow
- 🐾 Watch weight weekly — sudden loss is one of the earliest health signs
- 🐾 Never house with rabbits — different diets and disease risks make it unsafe



Cleaning & Care

A simple rhythm keeps everyone healthy



Every day

- 🐾 Spot clean — remove wet bedding, droppings & leftover fresh food
- 🐾 Rinse and refill the water bottle or bowl

Every week

- 🐾 Full cage clean: replace all bedding and wipe down surfaces
- 🐾 Deep-clean the water bottle with a bottle brush to prevent algae buildup
- 🐾 Wash food dishes with warm, soapy water

Good to know

- 🐾 Nail trims: roughly every 4-6 weeks
- 🐾 Brushing: weekly for short-haired guinea pigs, more often for long-haired breeds like Peruvians
- 🐾 Avoid scented cleaners or air fresheners near the cage — guinea pigs have sensitive respiratory systems



Health & Vet Care

A little routine goes a long way



The usual schedule

- 🐾 First check-up within the first week or two, with an exotics-experienced vet
- 🐾 Annual wellness visits for healthy adults
- 🐾 Twice-yearly visits are wise for guinea pigs over 4 years old
- 🐾 Ask about safe nail-trim frequency and dental checks

Call the vet if you notice

- ♥ Not eating hay or produce for 6+ hours — can signal GI stasis, a real emergency
- ♥ Few or no droppings, or unusually small/dry ones
- ♥ Sneezing, discharge, or noisy breathing (respiratory infections are common)
- ♥ Hunched posture, teeth grinding, or drooling (overgrown teeth or pain)

My guinea pig's vet info

Clinic: _____

Phone: _____

Emergency clinic: _____

Phone: _____



Cool Guinea Pig Facts

A little trivia to impress your friends



1

Guinea pigs aren't pigs, and they're not from Guinea — they're originally from the Andes region of South America.

2

Baby guinea pigs (called pups) are born fully furred with teeth, and can nibble solid food within hours of birth.

3

A guinea pig's teeth never stop growing for their entire life.

4

Guinea pigs have more than 11 distinct vocalizations, from wheeks to purrs to rumbles.

5

Like humans, guinea pigs can't produce their own vitamin C and must get it from food.

6

A happy, excited hop-and-twist is called 'popcorning.'

7

Guinea pigs are born with their eyes already open.

8

With good care, guinea pigs typically live 5-8 years — longer than many people expect for a small pet.

9

A soft, low rumbling purr usually means a relaxed, content guinea pig — very different from the sharp chattering sound that signals irritation.

10

Guinea pigs were domesticated over 3,000 years ago in South America, originally for food, long before they became beloved pets.

